

Chapter 142-3

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Liang Shi had chosen a dining location near Xu Qingzhu's company, which happened to coincide with her lunch break.

It was Xu Qingzhu and Chen Mian's first time meeting. Neither of them talked much.

After Liang Shi introduced them to each other, things quieted down.

When they sat down, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were on one side, while Chen Mian and Liang Wanwan naturally sat together on the other side.

Liang Wanwan sat on the inside and didn't take off her coat.

It was a bit hot inside the restaurant. Chen Mian was the first to notice and asked casually: "Aren't you hot?"

"Huh?" Liang Wanwan looked toward Chen Mian, but after just one glance, she quickly averted her gaze. "No... a little..."

Her voice trembled as she spoke, nearly biting her own tongue. She kept her eyes lowered, biting her lower lip, cursing herself for being stupid in her heart.

She quickly took off her coat, but her palms were still damp.

Liang Wanwan glanced at Chen Mian from the corner of her eye.

Liang Shi even teased her: "Wanwan, sitting and eating with your idol shouldn't make you this nervous, right?"

"Huh?" Liang Wanwan stumbled over her words again. "It's... it's okay..."

She didn't even know what to say—there were no suitable words for her to express herself.

Xu Qingzhu took everything in and placed some food in Liang Wanwan's bowl, comforting her: "Don't listen to your sister's nonsense. Just eat."

Liang Wanwan picked up her chopsticks, her head lowered as far as it could go. Through the gaps in her hair, Xu Qingzhu could see her ears, red as if they were on fire.

Chen Mian didn't have much of a reaction.

She had always been unconventional. No matter who she was eating with, she never felt awkward—she just calmly ate the food in front of her.

Until a plate of stir-fried vegetables was brought to the table.

To make the dish look nice, plain white lily flowers had been placed on the edge of the plate as decoration.

Chen Mian stared at those lily flowers, briefly lost in thought. Liang Shi was about to start eating when Chen Mian grabbed her wrist. "Wait."

Liang Shi: "?"

Chen Mian took out her phone, snapped a photo of that dish, then said calmly: "Continue."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi ate a bite of food in a daze before it dawned on her. "Is it because Qi Jiao likes lily flowers?"

Chen Mian's hand holding the chopsticks paused, and she gave a small nod.

Suddenly, the meal didn't taste quite right anymore.

Chen Mian curved her lips into a smile, and warmth appeared in those world-weary eyes of hers: "The plating is quite nice."

"Mm." Liang Shi responded perfunctorily.

Everyone at this meal had their own preoccupations.

After hearing the name Qi Jiao, Liang Wanwan lowered her head, her hand holding the chopsticks even trembling slightly.

Xu Qingzhu observed them all without showing any sign of it.

As for Liang Shi, she was probably the one eating most carefreely.

After the meal, Chen Mian said she had things to do and needed to leave. Liang Wanwan also had to return to school.

When they compared notes, it turned out both of them were heading to the Communication University.

So Chen Mian hailed a taxi directly. After getting in, she called out: "Little sister, come on, let's go together."

Liang Wanwan stood in place, somewhat at a loss. She looked toward Liang Shi.

Liang Shi patted her shoulder: "Go back and study hard. If you need money, just tell me."

Liang Wanwan bit her lip. "Okay."

Her sweaty palms and rapidly beating heart made her somewhat resistant to sharing a car with Chen Mian.

Especially having to sit together in the back seat.

But she actually really wanted to.

In the end, she got in the car, though Chen Mian sat on the other side, quite far from her.

As if they didn't know each other.

The taxi drove off into the distance. Xu Qingzhu watched Liang Shi's back, while Liang Shi watched the car drive away.

After a moment, Liang Shi withdrew her gaze. When she turned around, she unexpectedly met Xu Qingzhu's eyes.

"What is it?" Liang Shi asked. "Why are you looking at me?"

"Because you're good-looking." Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled, her gaze softening.

Liang Shi: "..."

She stepped forward and took Xu Qingzhu's hand. "When are you going back up?"

"Whenever." Xu Qingzhu said: "I don't have any meetings this afternoon."

Liang Shi asked: "Don't you have other things to take care of?"

"They're not very important matters." Xu Qingzhu said: "So I can put them off for a while."

"You should still handle them." Liang Shi squeezed her fingers. "Otherwise you'll have to bring work home again tonight."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu turned her head and raised an eyebrow. "Teacher Liang."

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

"You have a lot of objections to me working at home?" Xu Qingzhu said.

The winter wind was strong. The two walked very close together, and Xu Qingzhu's voice sounded as if it were right by her ear.

Liang Shi immediately denied it: "How could I? I'm just worried you won't sleep well at night."

"If you'd stop messing around for a bit," Xu Qingzhu said, "I'd be able to sleep well."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi sheepishly touched the tip of her nose. Knowing she was in the wrong, she leaned in close to her ear and said: "It's just that you're too lovable."

"But I won't mess around tonight." Liang Shi promised: "I'll let you sleep well."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Really?"

Liang Shi: "More real than pearls."¹

Footnotes:

¹ **More real than pearls** (比珍珠還真): A Chinese expression used to emphasize that something is absolutely true/genuine. It plays on the word "真" (zhēn) which means both "real/true" and sounds similar to "珍" (zhēn) in "珍珠" (pearl). It's a playful way of saying "absolutely true" or "I swear it's real."